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ANGOLA In visit, Biden calls U.S. 'all in' on Africa

LUANDA, Angola - Joe Biden on Tuesday used the first visit to Angola by a U.S. president to promote billions of dollars of commitments to the sub-Saharan African nation and speak at a slavery museum, where he'll acknowledge the trafficking that once linked the nations' economies.

"The United States is all in on Africa," Biden told Angolan President João Lourenço, who called Biden's visit a key turning point in U.S.-Angola relations dating back to the Cold War.

But even as the trip was meant to counter China's influence on the African continent of over 1.4 billion people by showcasing a U.S. commitment of $3 billion for the Lobito Corridor railway redevelopment linking Zambia, Congo and Angola, China announced its own move.

The corridor across southern Africa is meant to make it easier to move raw materials for export and advance the U.S. presence in a region rich in critical minerals used in batteries for electric vehicles, electronic devices and clean energy technologies.

China already has heavy investments in mining and processing African minerals, and on Tuesday it announced it is banning exports to the United States of gallium, germanium, antimony and other high-tech materials. It came a day after the U.S. expanded its list of Chinese technology companies subject to controls.

The U.S. for years has built relations in Africa through trade, security and humanitarian aid. The 800-mile (1,300-kilometer) railway upgrade is different, with shades of China's Belt and Road infrastructure strategy in Africa and other parts of the world.

Biden will visit the coastal city of Lobito on Wednesday for a look at the corridor's Atlantic Ocean outlet. The project also has drawn financing from the European Union, the Group of Seven leading industrialized nations, a Western-led private consortium and African banks.

It was not clear how much of the U.S. commitments had been delivered and how much will depend on the Trump administration.

White House national security spokesperson John Kirby said the corridor's completion is "going to take years." That means much of it may fall to Donald Trump, who takes office on Jan. 20.

Asked whether the project could proceed without Trump's support, Kirby said the Biden administration's hopes "that they see the value too, that they see how it will help drive a more secure, more prosperous, more economically stable continent."

Kirby also insisted that the corridor was about more than simply trying to outpace Beijing.

"We're not asking countries to choose between us and Russia and China. We're simply looking for reliable, sustainable, verifiable investment opportunities that the people of Angola and the people of the continent can rely on," he said.

One Angolan, 19-year-old Ladislau Ngola, called Biden's visit "very important for our country as the Lobito Corridor will create lots of jobs for young people." Julião Oliveira said "Africa in general" would benefit, too.

- Associated Press

NEW YORK Trump set to attend Notre Dame festivities

NEW YORK - President-elect Donald Trump will attend the reopening celebration for Notre Dame Cathedral in Paris this weekend, his first foreign trip since the election.

The cathedral is set to reopen Saturday after more than five years of reconstruction following a devastating fire in 2019 that engulfed and nearly destroyed the soaring Paris landmark. The ceremonies being held Saturday and Sunday will be high-security affairs, with about 50 heads of state and government expected to attend.

Trump announced that he will be among them in a post on his Truth Social site Monday evening.

"It is an honor to announce that I will be traveling to Paris, France, on Saturday to attend the re-opening of the Magnificent and Historic Notre Dame Cathedral, which has been fully restored after a devastating fire five years ago," he wrote. "President Emmanuel Macron has done a wonderful job ensuring that Notre Dame has been restored to its full level of glory, and even more so. It will be a very special day for all!"

The trip will be Trump's first abroad since he won November's presidential election. He traveled to Scotland and Ireland in May 2023, as a candidate, to visit his local golf courses.

Trump was president in 2019 when a massive fire engulfed Notre Dame, collapsing its spire and threatening to destroy one of the world's greatest architectural treasures, known for its mesmerizing stained glass.

Trump watched the inferno in horror, along with the rest of the world.

"So horrible to watch the massive fire at Notre Dame Cathedral in Paris," he wrote on what was then named Twitter, offering his advice to the city.

"Perhaps flying water tankers could be used to put it out. Must act quickly!" he wrote.

French officials appeared to respond shortly after, noting that "All means" were being used to extinguish the flames, "except for water-bombing aircrafts which, if used, could lead to the collapse of the entire structure of the cathedral."

Trump also spoke with Macron and Pope Francis at the time to offer his condolences and said he had offered them "the help of our great experts on renovation and construction."

Trump and Macron have had a complicated relationship.

During Trump's first term in office, Macron proved to be among the world leaders most adept at managing the American president's whims as he tried to develop a personal connection built in no small part on flattery.

Macron was the guest of honor at Trump's first state dinner and Trump traveled to France several times. But the relationship soured as Trump's term progressed and Macron criticized him for questioning the need for NATO and raising doubts about America's commitment to the mutual-defense pact.

As he ran for a second term this year, Trump often mocked Macron on the campaign trail, imitating his accent and threatening to impose steep tariffs on wine and champagne bottles shipped to the U.S. if France tried to tax American companies.

After Trump won another term last month, Macron rushed to win favor with the president-elect. He was among the first global leaders to congratulate Trump - even before The Associated Press called the race in his favor - and beat UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer to the punch in delivering a congratulatory phone call.

"Congratulations, President @realDonaldTrump," Macron posted on X early on Nov 6. "Ready to work together as we did for four years. With your convictions and mine. With respect and ambition. For more peace and prosperity."

Macron and other European leaders are trying to persuade Trump not to abandon America's support for Ukraine in its fight against Russia's nearly three-year invasion. European leaders hope to convince Trump that a victory by Russia would be viewed as a defeat for the U.S. - and for the incoming president, by extension - hoping to sell him on the need to pursue an end to the war more favorable to Kyiv than he might otherwise seek.

Trump over the weekend announced that he intends to nominate real estate developer Charles Kushner, the father of his son-in-law, Jared Kushner, to serve as ambassador to France. The elder Kushner was pardoned by Trump in December 2020 after pleading guilty years earlier to tax evasion and making illegal campaign donations.

The reopening of Notre Dame will be an elaborate, multi-day celebration, beginning Saturday.

Paris Archbishop Laurent Ulrich will preside at a reopening service that afternoon, banging on Notre Dame's shuttered doors with his staff to reopen them, according to the cathedral's website.

The archbishop will also symbolically reawaken Notre Dame's thunderous grand organ. The fire that melted the cathedral's lead roofing coated the huge instrument in toxic dust. Its 8,000 pipes have been painstakingly disassembled, cleaned and retuned.

- Associated Press

CALIFORNIA State moves to shield policies from Trump

SACRAMENTO, Calif. - California Gov. Gavin Newsom and state lawmakers returned to the state Capitol on Monday to begin a special session to protect the state's progressive policies ahead of another Trump presidency.

The Democratic governor, a fierce critic of President-elect Donald Trump, is positioning California to once again be the center of a resistance effort against the conservative agenda. He is asking his Democratic allies in the Legislature, who hold supermajorities in both chambers, to approve additional funding for the attorney general's office to prepare for a robust legal fight against anticipated federal challenges.

"We will work with the incoming administration and we want President Trump to succeed in serving all Americans," Newsom said in a statement. "But when there is overreach, when lives are threatened, when rights and freedoms are targeted, we will take action."

Democratic Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel on Monday introduced legislation to set aside $25 million for legal fees to respond to potential attacks by the Trump administration on state policies regarding civil rights, climate change, immigration and abortion access.

Democratic state Sen. Scott Wiener introduced a budget bill that includes the $25 million for the Department of Justice, which Newsom proposed, and an additional $10 million to help county and city attorneys protect policies from challenges by the federal government.

California sued the first Trump administration more than 120 times to various levels of success.

Trump often depicts California as representing all he sees wrong in America. Democrats, who hold every statewide office in California and have commanding margins in the Legislature and congressional delegation, outnumber registered Republicans by nearly 2-to-1 statewide.

Trump called the Democratic governor "Newscum" during a campaign stop in Southern California and has relentlessly lambasted the Democratic stronghold over its large number of immigrants in the U.S. illegally, its homeless population and its thicket of regulations.

Trump also waded into a water rights battle over the endangered delta smelt, a tiny fish that has pitted environmentalists against farmers, and threatened to withhold federal aid to a state increasingly under threat from wildfires. He also vowed to follow through with his campaign promise of carrying out the mass deportation of immigrants without legal status and prosecuting his political enemies.

Before the special session began, state lawmakers swore in more than two dozen new members and elected leaders for the 2025 legislative session. Lawmakers voted to convene the special session largely along party lines.

"This special session is about sticking up for Californians and for California values," Wiener said. "It is about ensuring that the president of the United States and his administration actually follow the law."

Hundreds of people demonstrated around the Capitol on Monday to urge the Legislature to try to stop Trump's mass deportation plans. They carried banners that said "Not one cent for mass deportation" and "MAGA out of California."

State Attorney General Rob Bonta said his office will protect the state's immigration population, while Newsom last week unveiled a proposal to revive a rebate program for electric vehicle purchases if the incoming Trump administration eliminates a federal tax credit for people who buy electric cars. Newsom is also considering creating a backup disaster relief fund for the wildfire-prone state after Trump's threats.

Bonta announced legislation Monday aimed at bolstering reproductive rights in the state, including by allowing the attorney general to seek monetary penalties against local governments that infringe on those rights. The proposals are part of the state's efforts to guarantee abortion access after the U.S. Supreme Court overturned Roe v. Wade.

Republican lawmakers blasted Newsom and his Democratic allies over the special session. State Sen. Kelly Seyarto, a Republican representing Murrieta in Southern California, said the session would create a more adversarial relationship with the federal government.

"What we're doing today is sending that exact message - that we are going to fight tooth and nail for everything. And you know what? That means they're going to fight us tooth and nail for everything," Seyarto said of the proposed legislation.

Legislators also are expected to spend the year discussing ways to protect

- Associated Press

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